cheer to the ruling party. The Siddaramaiah-led government was expecting to win in more than 14 of Karnataka's 28 Lok Sabha constituencies, but it could manage to bag only nine. This, incidentally, was the exact number of seats the Congress had won in 2014 during Siddaramaiah's first term as CM. Which means the Congress, which stormed to power in Karnataka in May 2023, has been unable to reverse the paradoxical pattern that has held in the state for the past two decades—of Karnataka voters drawing a clear line between who they vote for in the assembly polls and in the general elections.

Since 2004, the Congress has come to power twice in Karnataka with a clear majority but has been unable to cross single digits in the Lok Sabha polls. In this period, the BJP has consistently won the lion's share of seats in every Lok Sabha election even though it has fallen shy of an outright majority in state polls. With 17 Lok Sabha seats, the BJP remains at the top of the pecking order in this general election as well, and NDA partner Janata Dal (Secular) stands third with two seats.

Addressing a press conference on June 5 after the results were announced, CM Siddaramaiah said, as though to console himself, "The vote share of both the BJP and JD(S) has decreased. Our share in polling has increased, but we could not win as many seats as we had calculated." Hitting back at the ruling party in the state, BJP state president B.Y. Vijayendra told the media, "There's no reason for the chief minister to celebrate. The people of Karnataka have clearly shown their trust in Prime Minister Modi's performance over Congress promises." The BJP's tally, though is down eight seats from its 25-seat haul in 2019.

TOTAL LOK SABHA SEATS 28

	BJP	INC	JD(S)
2024	17 (46.1%)	9 (45.4%)	2 (5.6%)
2019	25 (51.4%)	1 (31.9%)	1 (9.7%)

An Independent candidate allied to NDA won one seat in 2019

Vote share in ( )

An appraisal of how senior leaders fared in their respective strongholds is now likely to determine Congress's future course of action

Meanwhile, the Congress's failure to reach its target tally has come as a blow to deputy CM D.K. Shivakumar, given the party's lacklustre performance in seats dominated by Vokkaliga voters. The community, designated other backward class (OBC) in Karnataka, is among the dominant ones in the state; Shivakumar, a Vokkaliga himself, has been vying with the family of JD(S) patriarch H.D. Deve Gowda for captaincy of the community.

SOUTHERN ROADBLOCK

A caste-based analysis of the results throws clearer light on the voting pattern in Karnataka. Half of the Congress's 14 seats came from northern Karnataka, where it swept all five seats in the backward northeastern region of Kalyana Karnataka, home to Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge. The party picked up two more seats—in Chikkodi and Davanagere, both located in the Veerashaiva-Lingayat heartland. These victories are being attributed to the respective clout the families of state PWD minister Satish Jarkiholi and veteran Congress legislator Shamanur Shivashankarappa enjoy here. The BJP, which has been wooing the Veerashaiva-Lingayat community, took the remaining seven seats in the north.

The Congress failed to register much of a presence when it came to southern Karnataka, dominated by Vokkaliga voters, where it won a dismal two of 14 seats. "The Vokkaligas have moved away from the Congress," says political commentator Narendar Pani. Of the six Vokkaliga candidates fielded by the Congress in the Old Mysuru region, only one, Shreyas Patel in Hassan, managed to win. "The performance of the Congress party in the Old Mysuru region has fallen compared to the assembly election, but that has been a trend for a long time," Shivakumar said at a press conference. The Vokkaliga community has traditionally rallied behind JD(S) chief Deve Gowda and his family. However, a year back, the Karnataka deputy CM had succeeded in pushing back the JD(S) to secure a handsome tally from the Old Mysuru region for the Congress. This feat, along with the party's impressive scorecard of 135 seats in the 224-member Karnataka assembly, had placed Shivakumar—also the Karnataka Pradesh Congress Committee chief—as a firm contender for the CM's post alongside Siddaramaiah. That may now be in jeopardy.

All through this past year, there has been an undertone of oneupmanship between the two top leaders, with Shivakumar making no attempts to disguise his chief ministerial aspirations in the current tenure. There have also been periodic nudges from other Congress seniors to be accommodated as deputy CMs alongside Shivakumar. That demand could possibly resurface following the party's dismal show in south Karnataka, says Pani.

Also likely is an appraisal of how other senior leaders, especially ministers, fared in their strongholds, as the Congress does a performance review. Its main worry will be how the BJP-JD(S) attempt to consolidate the Veerashaiva-Lingayats and Vokkaligas seems to be succeeding. The Congress must act before the trend takes root. ■